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FREE PLAYBOOK · 2026 EDITION

The 2026 Travel Careers Playbook

The jobs in demand, the skills that get you hired, and the LinkedIn moves that get you noticed by travel recruiters.

8
travel roles worth targeting

10
LinkedIn moves recruiters notice

30
day plan you can start today

01 · WHY TRAVEL, WHY NOW

One of the world's biggest employers is short of people

Travel keeps growing, and employers are struggling to find people with the right skills. That gap is your opening.

376M

jobs supported by Travel and Tourism in 2026, about one in every nine worldwide

WTTC

43M

of the 89M new travel jobs expected by 2035 could be hard to fill for lack of skilled workers

WTTC, via El Tiempo

1.52B

international tourist arrivals in 2025, a record

UN Tourism

66%

of recruiters say finding qualified talent got harder in the last year

LinkedIn research

40–44M

projected outbound trips by Indian travellers in 2026, up from 37–39M in 2025. More travellers means more jobs in agencies, airlines, hotels and travel tech.

Government of India Annual Tourism Snapshot 2025, via The Travigator

02 · WHERE THE JOBS ARE

8 travel roles worth targeting

01 **Travel advisor**

The booking agent has become a consultant who designs complex trips. Listed among LinkedIn's fastest-growing jobs. IATA

02 **Corporate travel and MICE sales**

Selling business travel, events and group trips to companies. Strong B2B sales skills travel well here.

03 **Revenue and pricing**

Setting hotel and airline prices using demand data. A natural fit for analytical minds.

04 **Travel tech: product, operations, support**

The apps and platforms behind every booking need people who understand both travel and software.

05 **Digital and performance marketing**

Search, social and content for airlines, hotels, agencies and travel startups.

06 **Data analyst**

Reading booking trends to personalise offers and marketing. IATA

07 **Sustainable and experience design**

Building low-impact, culturally respectful itineraries. IATA

08 **Guest experience and hotel operations**

Front office, reservations and guest relations. Often the fastest way into the industry.

03 · SKILLS THAT GET YOU HIRED

Human skills plus digital skills

Customer service still matters most in travel, but employers increasingly want people who can also work with data and AI.

LINKEDIN'S MOST IN-DEMAND SKILLS	RANK
Communication	1
Customer service	2
Project management	4
Management	5
Analytics	6
Sales	8

Source: LinkedIn Talent Blog

+70%

growth in US jobs requiring AI literacy skills such as prompt engineering, year over year

LinkedIn Economic Graph

+113%

rise in marketing job posts requiring AI literacy, year over year

Adobe and LinkedIn

The travel-specific edge

Cultural sensitivity, sustainability know-how and emotional intelligence for wellness and luxury travel, according to IATA.

04 · GET FOUND ON LINKEDIN

10 LinkedIn moves for travel careers

01 **List at least 5 skills**
Members who list skills get up to 2x more profile views and 4x more messages.

02 **Mix soft and hard skills**
People who list both get promoted 8% faster than those listing hard skills only.

03 **Write a headline recruiters search**
"Travel Consultant | Corporate Travel | Amadeus | Customer Experience" beats "Seeking opportunities".

04 **Add a clear, friendly photo**
Travel is a people business, and first impressions count.

05 **Turn on Open to Work**
Set it to recruiters only if you are currently employed.

06 **Follow the companies you want to work for**
You see their news and openings first, and recruiters notice followers.

07 **Set job alerts**
Search "travel", "tourism", "hospitality" and "travel tech" for your city.

08 **Comment before you apply**
A useful comment on a company post puts your name in front of its team.

09 **Share one post a month**
A trip insight, a trend or a lesson from work builds your profile.

10 **Message, don't spam**
A short, specific note to someone in the role you want beats 50 generic requests.

Moves 1 and 2: LinkedIn Talent Blog

05 · WORK AND TRAVEL

Turn work trips into travel

81%

of business travellers have extended an international work trip for leisure

Mastercard Travel Trendline

63%

plan to take several shorter trips in 2026

KAYAK

How to make it work

01 **Ask early**
Propose leisure days when the trip is planned, not after it is booked.

02 **Pay your own extra days**
Offer to cover extra nights and any fare difference, and say so upfront.

03 **Pick conference cities well**
Events in travel hubs make it easy to add a weekend.

04 **Network on the road**
Message local industry contacts on LinkedIn before you arrive.

Big travel events are career events

Trade shows like WTM London, ITB Berlin and Arabian Travel Market are where travel companies meet, hire and partner. Follow companies attending, and say hello on LinkedIn before the show.

06 · YOUR 30-DAY PLAN

Start this week

- [ ] Week 1: Create or update your LinkedIn profile with photo, headline and 5+ skills
- [ ] Week 1: Turn on Open to Work and set travel job alerts for your city
- [ ] Week 2: Follow 20 travel companies you would like to work for
- [ ] Week 2: Take one free AI or data basics course and add it to your profile
- [ ] Week 3: Comment usefully on 3 posts from travel companies each week
- [ ] Week 3: Message 5 people in the role you want, with one specific question each
- [ ] Week 4: Publish one short post about a travel trend or lesson
- [ ] Week 4: Apply to 10 roles that match your skills

No LinkedIn account yet?
Create one free at linkedin.com/signup. It takes about 3 minutes, and it's where most travel recruiters look first.

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